

**FILM DIRECTOR
AND SESSION
CHAIRPERSON
KARAN JOHAR
(LEFT) AND KHAN**



REUBEN SINGH

(God is merciful and kind. He helps you attain enlightenment. He does not make you destroy temples and mosques.) The Bible taught us to offer the other cheek if somebody slaps one of yours. Not another Crusade. God gave us art as a means to peace, overcoming hatred and living in harmony.

Unfortunately, art will not be able to control this hatred now. It's going to take a long time for it to settle. Or maybe destroy us all in trying to do so. The uncertainty will not go away but art does give us in all its colours a chance to see the brighter side of life. I think we should

choose it as a lifestyle before it is too late or at least keep using it to divert ourselves for a few moments to handle the hatred around us. I would like to leave you with a sad scene. Mother Art is weeping looking at its Child Religion, its child following the path of hatred, and Father God is trying to give peace, beauty and love a chance. Let us kill each other because we want to but please stop using His name as an excuse. Now, this is a picture as a Hindi film artiste I want to leave you with. I hope a lot of people will understand it and go to see it. I hope it is a superhit. I will be very happy as a film star if somebody understands it.

I'll just tell you some of the new things I have learnt today. I didn't know what conclave means. The closest I came to it is that I used to live in Safdarjung Enclave when I was in Delhi. So conclave? It is a party where everybody sits, smiles and jokes. Thank you very much for introducing me to the word conclave.

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DISCUSSION

Q. You have been rated as the 41st most powerful man in the world. What do you feel about that?

A. I am a Muslim; I am also a modern Muslim. I take this iconic status very seriously. And I hope somehow through my work, the way I speak about Islam, youngsters will take a cue from what I do. They need to understand that being a Muslim is not a bad thing. I want to teach my children the right thing.

Q. Do you feel like doing something about it through your art form?

A. I would like to, though I still hold the belief that the entertainment I provide is basically for entertainment. Within it, if they can somehow hide a little message of the things that I believe in, then it's good. But they should not overtake the entertainment.

Q. Do you think by denying the immense power of art, in your case films, you are doing a

diservice to the society?

A. Since I started acting, I have never thought of this. Maybe younger people have started to think this way. I watch films to escape from the problems that I had when I was young and even now. Maybe that is why I make escapist kind of cinema. I never thought cinema would change my life. Maybe I should start thinking like that.

Q. Can cinema and art show the way from religion to spirituality?

A. I think spirituality is a private thing. It has to come from within. For me, acting is spiritual. It will be fantastic if we can do it through cinema. But if I do it through cinema, my spirituality may not work for you. It will stop being universal. But it is a good thought. The only thing is that the film won't be a hit.

Q. Do you think the reaction to you would be different if you

were Shekhar Krishna?

A. Shekhar Radha Krishna. I don't think there would be any difference. I have never been made aware through my profession, or otherwise, about religion in this country. I think artists have this tendency to transcend divisions.

Q. How do you perceive corporates entering into films?

A. The corporate culture is a little too cold, strangely for films. When I meet them, they ask, what are the returns on our film? Cinema is a strange art form that is measured on the anvil of finance. Normally art is for art's sake. But it is not good cinema for you or for me unless it is a hit.

Q. Today, young people dream of being film stars and cricket stars. How do you foresee their future?

A. I think every youngster should be encouraged. All art forms have reached a level where they are commercially viable. I would like my

children to become actors. Not because they are my children. Just as a profession. And even more than that I want my daughter to be a sportswoman. A lot of hatred would be reduced if we were sportsmen. I think it teaches us to lose but not be losers.

Q. Have you been criticised by Muslim hardliners for being a moderate Muslim?

A. Not yet. I am careful about that. And I have never spoken about Islam in a derogatory or wrong manner. I do speak the word of the Quran, which is actually quite like the word of the Bible, of the Tora and of the Gita. Same novel, same topic, just different languages. They are just translations.

Q. What can you and others like you do to promote peace?

A. Ask what not the film industry can do for you. Ask what Pakistan and India can do for each other. Don't put it on us.